The Journal of Open Source Software

voice: A Comprehensive R Package for Audio Analysis

Filipe Jaeger Zabala [1,2*] **and Giovanni Abrahão Salum** [1,3*]

1 Graduate Program of Psychiatry and Behavioral Sciences, UFRGS, Brazil **2** Pontifical Catholic University of Rio Grande do Sul **3** Child Mind Institute, New York, NY 10022, USA * These authors contributed equally.

DOI: 10.xxxxxx/draft

Software

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Editor:

Submitted: 06 May 2025
Published: unpublished

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Summary

The `voice` package (Zabala, 2025) for R (R Core Team, 2024) is a free, open-source toolkit designed to streamline audio analysis by integrating music theory and advanced computational techniques. It enables researchers to extract, tag, and analyze voice data efficiently, supporting applications such as speech recognition, speaker identification, and mood inference. The package simplifies workflows through three core functions: `extract_features`, `tag`, and `diarize`. By bridging gaps in existing tools like `wrassp` (Winkelmann et al., 2024) and `tuneR` (Ligges et al., 2023), `voice` offers a unified solution for audio data analysis.

Statement of Need

Audio data analysis is complex due to variability in file formats and the lack of integrated tools. While packages like `seewave` (Sueur et al., 2008) provide foundational capabilities, they often require specialized knowledge. The `voice` package addresses these challenges by combining existing functionalities with novel features such as *Formant Removals*, which enhance predictive accuracy for tasks like sex classification.

Its user-friendly design makes it accessible to researchers in linguistics, psychology, and bioacoustics, where audio data remains underutilized. There are currently work fronts in these areas making use of `voice` functionalities. By simplifying the extraction and analysis of audio features, `voice` lowers the barrier to entry for researchers and expands the potential for audio data in scientific studies.

Features

Core Functions

1. **`extract_features`**:
   Extracts standardized audio features from files (e.g., *F0*, *Formant Dispersion*, *Gain*, *MFCC*), leveraging `wrassp` and `tuneR` while introducing new metrics to capture vocal tract characteristics.

2. **`tag`**:
   Attaches summarized audio features to datasets, supporting anonymization and privacy-aware analysis via a *6-number summary* (mean, median, standard deviation, coefficient of variation, interquartile range and median absolute deviation).

3. **`diarize`**:
   Identifies speaker segments using Python's `pyannote-audio` (Bredin et al., 2019), generating RTTM files for transcription and analysis.

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Novel Contributions

- **Formant Removals**:
  Isolates fundamental frequency (F0) from formants, improving feature interpretability for classification tasks.
- **Integration of R and Python**:
  Uses `reticulate` (Ushey et al., 2023) to combine R's statistical power with Python's tools.

Example Applications

Predicting Sex from Voice

The package was tested on open datasets (AESDD (Vryzas, Kotsakis, et al., 2018; Vryzas, Matsiola, et al., 2018), CREMA-D (Cao et al., 2014), Mozilla Common Voice (Ardila et al., 2019), RAVDESS (Livingstone & Russo, 2018) and VoxForge (VoxForge, 2023)) to predict sex from voice features. Results showed high accuracy across multiple model classes (Binary Logistic (Cramer, 2002), SVM (Vapnik, 2000), Random Forest (Breiman, 2001), and BART (Sparapani et al., 2021)), with formant removals ranking among the top predictive features.

Speaker Diarization

The `diarize` function has been used successfully, and as a didactic example was applied to a LibriVox recording of *The Adventures of Sherlock Holmes* by Conan Doyle, successfully segmenting the audio into speaker turns. This demonstrates the package's utility for applications in transcription and audio analysis.

Performance

The `voice` package efficiently processes audio files, with `extract_features` allowing parallelization and generating feature-rich data frames in seconds for typical audio lengths. The `diarize` function, while computationally intensive for long recordings, provides accurate segmentation and integrates seamlessly with R workflows.

Availability

The `voice` package is available on CRAN (https://CRAN.R-project.org/package=voice) and GitHub (https://github.com/filipezabala/voice). Documentation, including vignettes and examples, is provided to facilitate adoption.

Acknowledgments

The authors gratefully acknowledge Renfei Mao for their technical support and guidance in implementing the `gm` library (Mao, 2025).

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